



CRUSH OF FAITH

Nearly 1,000 pilgrims have died in stampedes at places of worship in the last five years. The death of over 220 in Jodhpur's Chamunda Devi temple last week is proof that state governments and temple authorities haven't learnt from the mistakes of the past.

■ By Rohit Parihar in Jodhpur

Until about four decades ago, the first day of the navratras used to be observed at the Chamunda Devi temple in Jodhpur with a mass sacrifice of goats. Then, the sanguinary ritual was banned. Religious devotion turned gory once again shortly before dawn on September 30 when 224 people were killed in a stampede at the 600-year-old temple built by Rao Jodha, the founding ruler of Jodhpur. More than 8,000 devotees had begun to queue up from a little past midnight outside the gates of the massive Mehrangarh Fort that houses the temple. They trooped in in batches of 500 through a narrow slope leading up to the small temple 100 yards away.

About two hours after the temple gates had opened for the day, the power failed. In the pre-dawn darkness, a part of the tent covering the slope collapsed, blocking the way. In the panic that ensued, a stampede broke out as the crowd attempted to break through the barricades. A morning which had begun in devotion and mirth—some devotees carried liquor as offerings for the deity—ended even before daybreak in chill, black horror. Bodies lay braided together and as Param Jyoti, IRS probationer and assistant superintendent of police said, “We could not pull them out. It was as if they were joined together.” It took Jyoti and her team nearly 90 minutes to clear the 100-yard stretch. The toll rose through the day but Jyoti believes that they were able to rescue more people than those who died. Matters